happy fluke—has any validity, one would need to address how and why the universe went so far overboard and achieved a state of *such* low entropy.

Even more pressing, if you truly can't trust memories and records, then you also can't trust the laws of physics. Their validity rests on numerous experiments whose positive outcomes are attested to only by those very same memories and records. So all the reasoning based on the time-reversal symmetry of the accepted laws of physics would be totally thrown into question, thereby undermining our understanding of entropy and the whole basis for the current discussion. By embracing the conclusion that the universe we know is a rare but every-so-often-expectable statistical fluctuation from a configuration of total disorder, we're quickly led into a quagmire in which we lose all understanding, including the very chain of reasoning that led us to consider such an odd explanation in the first place.[14]

Thus, by suspending disbelief and diligently following the laws of physics and the mathematics of entropy—concepts which in combination tell us that it is overwhelmingly likely that disorder will increase both toward the future *and* toward the past from any given moment—we have gotten ourselves neck deep in quicksand. And while that might not sound pleasant, for two reasons it's a very good thing. First, it shows with precision why mistrust of memories and records—something at which we intuitively scoff—doesn't make sense. Second, by reaching a point where our whole analytical scaffolding is on the verge of collapse, we realize, forcefully, that we *must* have left something crucial out of our reasoning.

Therefore, to avoid the explanatory abyss, we ask ourselves: what new idea or concept, beyond entropy and the time symmetry of nature's laws, do we need in order to go back to trusting our memories and our records—our experience of room-temperature ice cubes melting and not unmelting, of cream and coffee mixing but not unmixing, of eggs splattering but not unsplattering? In short, where are we led if we try to explain an asymmetric unfolding of events in spacetime, with entropy to our future higher, but entropy to our past *lower*? Is it possible?

It is. But only if things were very special early on.[14]